

The death of her father when she was six is thought to have spurred Lili to start composing. Her earliest work was the simple and poetic Nocturne (1911) for violin and piano. At the age of 19, she won the prestigious Prix de Rome for her cantata Faust et Hélène (1913), composed in just four weeks. She was the first woman to receive the award. This marked the turning point in her career, securing her a scholarship as composer-in-residence at the Villa Medici in Rome as well as a publishing contract.

The influence of Fauré, Debussy, and Wagner is evident in Boulanger's work, which also embraces religious themes (as in her psalm settings). Many of her major pieces were written during World War I, when she was often ill. Several of these are dark and brooding, as in Poème symphonique (1917) and Psalm 130, Du fond de l'âbime (Out of the depths, 1917–1918). By contrast, her Vieille prière bouddhique (1914–1917) and the sprightly D'un matin de printemps are more uplifting.

By 1918, although at a high point in her career, Boulanger was at a personal low, plagued by severe illness. Pie Jesu (for voice, strings, harp, and organ)—melancholic, sparse, beautiful—was completed on her deathbed. Her opera La Princesse Maleine (1916–1918) was unfinished at the time of her death at the age of 24.

“ Superior morally and spiritually ...

She became an example for me. ”

NADIA BOULANGER, ON HER SISTER, LILI